michaeltearedit

Travel Radio Australia, and we're here at MIPCOM in Khan, which is a fantastic event for creators and distributors of content from all over the world, and I'm at the Screen Australia stand, and I'm with Michael Tear, who's the Chief Executive Officer of a great company, Wild Bear Entertainment, from Canberra. Michael, welcome to the program. Thank you.

And Michael, tell us about, first of all, what you do and who you are, a bit about your background and what you're doing here at MIPCOM. Yes, I'm the CEO of Wild Bear. We're an Australian-based production company.

We've got offices in Canberra, Sydney, Brisbane and Melbourne, and an office in New Zealand. And we make docs, factual entertainment, TV series for Australian market and for the international market. And our genre is what they call specialist factual, which is natural history, history, science and engineering.

That's part of our business. We also do feature docs, feature documentaries, and then we also do, you know, more, I guess, shows for domestic market for broadcasters in Australia, like ABC and SBS and Stan and others. And tell us a bit about your background before we get into the shows themselves.

How did you get into all of this? Ah, well, that's, yes. Well, I studied media in university, and when I graduated, I couldn't find a job, so I decided to set up my company in partnership with my business partner I'm still working with, Search. And initially, we, you know, we just, we set up a really small company.

We were just looking for any kind of commissions. We started off doing corporate videos for brands and for agencies. And then later on, we moved into TV commercials.

And then after that, more, you know, more long form is what we call it. And the business has sort of grown from there. There's been a number of iterations.

We've merged with another couple of companies, and sort of it's, it's grown. Now, it's a reasonably resized company. We have about 130 people.

We do around 200 hours of TV, so that's really our story. And tell us about some of the projects that you've been involved with creating and that the Australian audience would know about. Well, I guess some of our key shows would, at the moment, the one that stands out is Stuff the British Stole with Mark Fennell.

We're going to just, just finish season three of that. We have shows like Gem Hunters, which is a sort of outback Aussie gold, not Aussie gold, but, you know, mining sort of dock. We've also done, you know, feature docks.

Playing with sharks was the Valerie Taylor story. It was about an amazing scientist who was a conservationist and it's sort of her life story. And the film ended up going to Sundance and being acquired by Disney.

So there's a whole kind of range of types of shows that we make. And tell us about your experience here at MIPCOMM. I suppose you've been coming here for a few years and what sort of things happen here at MIPCOMM for Wild Bear? It's a unique market.

It's always on the, on the, in the, in the diary. You know, we basically meet all of our buyers. We have about 40 or 50 meetings over the three days.

So we're, you know, a lot of the time it's catching up with people who we do business with. We are trying to find new opportunities, great opportunity for someone from Australia. You have to come a long way, but you get to talk to a lot of people and you get a lot of market intel.

You have a lot of conversations and you can synthesize that into a three or four days. And it's, it's just such a, it's such a unique opportunity. There's not that many markets around the world.

There's, there's lots, but all of them have sort of, you know, little idiosyncrasies all there. You know, maybe they're not the Americans don't come or the Europeans don't come. I mean, it is definitely more European market, this one, but it's, it's just a great opportunity to connect.

And then, you know, you also get socialized, you meet your, your buyers, you've got good relationships with, you can have meals, you can catch up outside the sort of frenetic pitching and, you know, it's all about building relationships. And being here in Khan, such a beautiful city here in, in the, on the French Riviera. And, and I must say that we're sitting on the screen Australia stand and it's much better this year than we've ever had, because we have this panoramic view over the marina here and the balcony.

And that's a big change from last year, isn't it? Last year, well, last for many years, we've been down in the bunker where there's no daylight. I don't know how we've managed to be elevated up here. So we overlook the marina.

We've got access to a little outside, outside table. And the weather in Khan at this time of year is often beautiful. It's blue skies, 23 degrees.

It's just, it's just a great place to, to come. And it's a long way to come, but at least when you get here, it's a beautiful spot to spend a week. And a lot of people know Khan from the Khan Film Festival, which is held earlier in the year.

I suppose this is a, this is a little bit bigger than the Khan Film Festival, isn't it? And for you guys who are creating all this content and, and getting your distribution deals, it's much more important than the Khan Film Festival. The Film Festival is much more about feature films. It's, there's a

competition.

It's about getting audience recognition. When, you know, and often you say, I'm going to Khan, everyone says, oh, the festival, which is kind of like what everyone remembers. But for us, it's about basically financing our projects.

So, you know, it's about meeting buyers. So I like it because it's, it is about business. It's about buying and selling.

And the Film Festival is about buying and selling finished films. But I guess we're kind of further up the evolution of these projects and we're, we're looking for money. So as is always, that's the way, the life of a producer.

You're always hunting for money and this is a great opportunity to meet a lot of people in a very condensed amount of time and hopefully raise some, raise some cash. Well, that's it because there's two tiers, isn't there? There's the creators and the money people and they both need each other. Yeah.

It's a symbiotic relationship. And for both of us, if I'm, because I'm more on the money side, I definitely need to understand the challenges and difficulties of making. But equally, the makers need to understand the budgets and, you know, what the expectations of the audience and the buyers are.

And again, as has always been in our industry and I feel privileged and I have an opportunity to represent creative people and their great projects and I, I think it's a privilege and I think it's a responsibility. So I take that seriously and I try to be as good as I possibly can be on the money side. And the great thing about being here in Khan, having an Australia stand here or a couple of stands together, we've got Screen Australia, ABC commercial.

It's a bit of a hub, a great networking hub for when you get back to. Yeah, it's great. It's friendly faces.

It's a location. There are lots of stands and a lot of buyers will meet you at stands, but a lot of people don't have a stand. So it's great that we can meet them here and we have a venue.

Otherwise you can, if you've got a half hour meeting slot, you don't want to be fiddling around looking for a table down in the lounge. So it's just a, it's a great asset and it's the little things that help and it's a, it's a real support for Australian producers who are a long way from home and after I'll spend a lot of money to get here and that little bit of extra help is really appreciated. Because just to walk around here is a, it's a lot of money.

It's a couple of thousand dollars just to walk around. Yeah. It's, I think it's a thousand euros for your registration and accommodation is not cheap, particularly at the time of these markets and meals and everything.

It's, it's, it is an expensive exercise. You know, we often hear our colleagues from North America complaining about the flights, but you know, it's something that as Australians, we're well aware that you, we need to, we need to travel a long way and it, it's definitely got increasingly expensive. I mean, airfares, the price of fuel, all of these are a real burden, but equally you need to be in the market.

You need to be here and you need to be here every year. It's like an ongoing commitment that you're in front of the buyers and you're, you know, you show that you're, you're ready for business and you're, you're delivering and you're always delivering. And just briefly tell us about a couple of, a couple of the upcoming productions that should, that the Australian audience should look out for, that you have in the pipeline.

Some of them are kind of in early stage and a bit of sensitive around financing, so. Or ones you've released recently that, that are going places. We've got a show upcoming on the ABC, which is called Wild Wild Whips and it's about a interesting character, whip-cracking, whip-cracking competitions.

So keep an eye out for that. It's kind of like a bit of a surprising, unusual outback characters and kind of an intriguing plot. How can people find out more? Michael Tear, the Chief Executive Officer of Wild Bear Entertainment, online.

You can visit our website, wildbear.tv. It has all our projects and hopefully there's something that you've seen there that you've really enjoyed and let us know about it. Great, thanks very much Michael for being part of the program. Thank you.